– PHOTO: C.V. SUBRAHMANYAM

Staff Reporter

- A boy suggests celebrating 'virtual Deepavali'
- Students from 24 schools participate in the programme

VISAKHAPATNAM: Deepavali, the festival of lights, should dispel the darkness in the lives of the less fortunate children and the poor rather than adding to noise and eco-pollution.

This was the broad opinion expressed by students of various schools who participated in a discussion on 'celebrating Deepavali in an eco-friendly manner', organised jointly by INTACH (Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage) and Symbiosis at the VUDA Children Theatre on Friday.

A participant felt that festivals have become status symbols. She felt that instead of ostentatious display of vanity one should go for community celebrations and share the joy with the less fortunate children. Another girl said that she would think of the child labourers, involved in the fireworks industry, before lighting a cracker this Diwali. "I will opt for diyas (earthern lamps)," she said when asked how she would celebrate the festival this year.

A boy came out with a novel idea of celebrating 'virtual Deepavali'. It doesn't cause noise pollution, eco-pollution or wastage of precious natural resources. He also suggested the use of energy-efficient appliances at home. Another boy felt that the media should create awareness on such issues.

One boy suggested the development of 'eco-friendly' crackers. Some of the participants felt that pooling the resources and celebrations at a common place would help in minimising the noise and eco-pollution levels besides doubling the joy of celebrations. Some felt that going for big idols and laddus for Ganesh Chaturthi and Duga Puja just for the sake of competition should be avoided.

Concern for birds

A girl said that she would burst less number of crackers this year and use the money saved to contribute to an orphanage. A boy expressed concern at the death of birds due to noise pollution on Diwali every year.

A lecturer from Gitam University Deepa More summed up the ideas of the students. She gave a PowerPoint presentation through which she highlighted the risk of accidents during Diwali, pollution of environment, collateral damage to huts and dry grass in the rural areas and the smoke as a potential threat to truck drivers on Diwali Day.

Workshop reaches out to the disabled

Staff Reporter

- A wheel chair sports and games festival to be organised in last week of November
- Rehabilitation centre for the disabled to be set up in the city

VISAKHAPATNAM: The three-day workshop organised by 'The Ability People', a city based NGO for supplying callipers, wheel chairs and artificial limbs for those immobilised physically due to spinal chord injuries and other factors, concluded on Friday. About 60 disabled people attended the workshop and 23 of them screened for supply of various appliances.

The organisation was founded in 2007 by a software engineer Dilip Patro who himself had been immobilised for several years due to a spinal chord injury he sustained in a road mishap. He is presently working for a Bangalore-based Software company Tata Elexi online from the confines of his home in the city.

More than a decade of unproductivity in his life caused by immobility had taught him valuable lessons and to rise from despair and once again become productive, says Mr. Patro during a chat with *The Hindu*. After regaining the lost happiness in life, he decided to make others happy by reaching out to people who had been immobilised physically. The NGO in partnership with 'Mobility India' Bangalore, is supplying best quality products like callipers, artificial limbs, wheel chairs and other appliances. Technical assistance and professional guidance based on WHO guidelines were being given to the beneficiaries.

Members

'The Ability People' has 440 registered members from all over South India and their objective is to bring immobile people out of the confines of their houses.

The organisation is also offering technology to modify cars and two wheelers as per the convenience of the disabled. So far 110 wheel chairs had been provided apart from other appliances. Most of the beneficiaries were supplied free of cost while to some at a subsidised price.

A wheel chair sports and games festival will be organised in the last week of November at the Port Stadium with the help of some public sector organisations in the city. A Rehabilitation Centre for the disabled will be set up shortly in the city.

